Women and Scars

Poetry by Deb Royce



Women and Scars by Deb Royce

ISBN: 978-1-61387-114-0

Copyright 2017 by SpeechGeek.

Free performance of this play for high school and college level competitive forensics is permitted. All other rights reserved.

This PDF version of this selection, e-published in 2015, is identical to the printed published version of this same publication dated 2015. This statement along with the entire printed PDF of this publication must be presented at any National Speech and Debate Association District or National event for the script to comply with NFL rules per the request of the Executive Director.

This and other selections of quality performance literature for competitive oral interpretation are published by SpeechGeek.

For more information and performance rights, contact **SpeechGeek.**

SpeechGeek
248 Arlington Park Dr.
Hot Springs, AR 71901

Phone: 1-888-742-2028
Email: thegeek@speechgeek.com
Web: www.speechgeek.com
Facebook: www.facebook.com/speechgeek

At first glance
You might not see
Behind the curtain of her hair and headscarf
But some women are aware of our wounded
Like a sick sixth sense
We can spot survivors
Like a sonar ping from a lost submarine.

I am reading her.

The right side of her face Is young and beautiful
The color of cardamom
the smoothness of silk

The left side of her face
Like a melted candle
The skin drips down
And meanders into an ancient riverbed
Cracked and barren
Eroded away
By streams of tears?
It's hard to say

And her one eye is white, like it's covered in liquid paper
Like the mistake was her
seeing

Grotesque

She is a gargoyle carved by a hateful hand
If she wasn't always stone, she surely is now
Because that's what happens
When your soft places go stale
When your happiness hollows out
When your body is used as a weapon against you

I've heard that in some countries
Acid rains down from the hands of men
To cut women down to size
To burn out the sin of beauty
To avoid the temptation of other men
For who could want such spoiled goods?

They call it honor
We call it horror
They call her property
I call it prophecy
Because women were always the keepers of blame
He was the wick, she was the flame
How could he be responsible for his actions?
Hers was the face that launched a thousand ships
She was the one who held an apple to his lips and sighed
"Just a bite"

So?

He denuded her mind of education - calling her the muse, merely inspiration
He industrialized her hands for exploitation - she was good enough to work, but not enough to earn
He strip-mined her womb for labor - she had a right to procreate, if that's what he wanted
He hunted her body for meat
He hunted her body for sport
He hunted her body for no reason at all
Just to watch it wither and die.
Don't you feel powerful?

And this woman
(The one with the scars)
She is no different
She is the story we all tell our daughters
Like a watercolor Picasso
A jungle of skin
A jumble of feminine burden
A topographic map of everything that is wrong with where she comes from
With where she is
With where we **all** live

But as bad as it is to see her bear the yoke
To see her shopping for groceries
Choosing what foods she can consume
with only half a working face

This is the sick part:

My mouth hungers
while throat parched
My eyes ache
While hands tremble

What started as a glance is now a full trance
Of envy

She wears her history on her face
like the wrinkles of hateful wisdom
And she cannot escape
But who can?
Who can escape the marks history and fate leaves on us?

No woman can.
Not her.
Not me.

That same death mask
Lives inside of me
It is the inner structure of my smiling skull

Those same dripping scars
Line cage of my chest
The insides of my legs
That whiteout eye is mine

Looking out at the world through damaged lenses

We are the sisterhood of burden
A society of souls
That you can't call survivors
Because parts of us didn't survive
We only look that way in this lighting
With thick makeup
And contortionist skills that make
Our grim mouths grin

We are monuments to what love can do
When it is loaded into the barrel of a cannon
And fired through a nursery of hope

All the while I recognize her as my own reflection
Still, echos of my worst self cry out
At least when the world sees her
They cannot unknown her
They cannot ignore what life has done to her

They may choose to judge
Or handle with silk gloves
But they know there is damage
They know there is pain
That the monster she is now was never the life she had planned

Some of us aren't so lucky
Some of us wear our terrors on the inside
We survive our horrors in silence
The world never knows